

Adverbs and adverb phrases: position

We can put adverbs and adverb phrases at the front, in the middle or at the end of a clause.

The front position of the clause is the first item in the clause:

Suddenly I felt afraid.

Yesterday detectives arrested a man and a woman in connection with the murder.

The end position of the clause is the last item in the clause:

Why do you always have to eat so fast?

The mid position is between the subject and the main verb:

Apples always taste best when you pick them straight off the tree.

Where there is more than one verb, mid position means after the first auxiliary verb or after a modal verb:

The government has occasionally been forced to change its mind. (after the first auxiliary verb)

You can definitely never predict what will happen. (after a modal verb)

We mightn't ever have met. (after the modal verb and before the auxiliary verb)

In questions, mid position is between the subject and the main verb:

Do you ever think about living there?

Adverbs usually come after the main verb *be*, except in emphatic clauses:

She's always late for everything.

When *be* is emphasised, the adverb comes before the verb:

Why should I have gone to see Madonna? I never was a fan of hers. (emphatic)

See also:

- [Adverb phrases](#)
- [Be as a main verb](#)

Types of adverbs and their positions

Different types of adverbs go in different places.

type	position	example
manner	They usually go in end position. They sometimes go in mid position if the adverb is not the most important part of the clause or if the object is very long.	<i>She ate quickly.</i> <i>She quickly ate her dinner and ran out.</i>
place	They usually go in end position. They sometimes go in front position, especially in writing.	<i>Can you come over here?</i> <i>We'll be at that table there.</i> <i>Here she sat.</i> <i>Outside, there was a small pond.</i>
time	They usually go in end position. They sometimes go in front position especially if we want to emphasise the adverb.	<i>I'm flying to Edinburgh tomorrow.</i> <i>Today, I'm going to clean the house.</i>
duration	They usually go in end position.	<i>I'm not staying long.</i>
frequency	They usually go in mid position. They sometimes go in front position. They can also go in end position. <i>Always, ever and never</i> do not usually go in front position.	<i>We often have friends to stay.</i> <i>I usually get up late on weekends.</i> <i>I could never swim fast.</i> <i>Sometimes she wore a woollen hat.</i> <i>We don't see them very often.</i> <i>Not: Never I could swim fast.</i>

type	position	example
degree	<i>Really, very, quite</i> usually go in mid position. <i>A lot</i> and <i>a bit</i> usually go in end position.	<i>I really like those pink flowers.</i> <i>We go to Ireland a lot.</i> <i>I'd just like to change things a bit.</i>
focusing	They usually go in mid position.	<i>He simply walked out without saying a word.</i>
certainty or obligation	Some go in mid position: <i>probably, possibly, certainly</i>. Others go in front position: <i>maybe, perhaps</i> or in end positions after a comma.	<i>It'll probably rain.</i> <i>Maybe Nick will know the answer.</i> <i>Can I get you a drink, or something to eat, perhaps?</i>
viewpoint	They usually go outside the clause, often at the beginning. They can sometimes go in mid position, especially in formal writing.	<i>Personally, I'd rather not go out.</i> <i>This must, frankly, be the craziest idea anyone has ever had.</i>
evaluative	They usually go outside the clause, often at the beginning. They can sometimes go in mid position. In informal speaking they can go in end position.	<i>Unfortunately, I forgot my swimming costume so I had to sit on the side and watch.</i> <i>We have stupidly forgotten the tickets.</i> <i>They missed the bus, apparently.</i>

Manner, place and time

Adverbs of manner, place and time usually come in end position:

He played brilliantly.

If the verb has an object, the adverb comes after the object:

We [verb]made [object]a decision [adverb]quickly then left.

When there is more than one of the three types of adverb together, they usually go in the order: manner, place, time:

You start off [manner]slowly [time]in the beginning.

Not: You start off in the beginning slowly.

James played [manner] [place]brilliantly in the match on [time]Saturday. (preferred to James played brilliantly on Saturday in the match.)

Warning:

We don't put adverbs between the verb and the object:

She [verb]plays [object]the piano [adverb]really well. I've heard her.

Not: She plays really well the piano.

I don't watch the TV very often.

Evaluative and viewpoint

Adverbs indicating the attitude and point of view of the speaker or writer usually go at the beginning. These adverbs are called sentence adverbs because they refer to the whole sentence or utterance:

Actually, I think the meeting is on Wednesday, not Thursday.

Obviously, we can't tell you the result but we can give you an indication.

Position with *here* and *there*

Warning:

If the subject is a pronoun (*it/he/she/you* etc.), it comes directly after the adverbs *here* and *there*. If the subject is a noun, it comes directly after the verb:

Here she is.

Not: Here is she.

There it goes.

Not: There goes it.

Here comes the bus.

Not: Here the bus comes.

See also:

- [Adverbs: types](#)